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A Survey of Tense, Aspect, and Mood in Bura-Pabir

ORTHOGRAPHIC GUIDELINES

The following orthographic conventions were utilized¹:

<a> /a/
 /b/
 <ɓ> /ɓ/
 <ch> /tʃ/
 <d> /d/
 <dz> /dz/
 <dʒ> /dʒ/
 <e> /e/
 <f> /f/
 <g> /g/
 <gh> /ɣ/
 <h> /h/
 <i> /i/
 <ə> /i/
 <j> /dʒ/
 <k> /k/
 <kh> /x/
 <k'> /k'/*
 <l> /l/
 <m> /m/
 <n> /n/
 <ng> /ŋ/
 <ny> /ɲ/
 <o> /o/
 <p> /p/
 <r> /r/
 <s> /s/
 <sh> /ʃ/
 <t> /t/
 <ts> /ts/
 <u> /u/
 <v> /v/
 <w> /w/
 <y> /y/
 <z> /z/
 <zh> /ʒ/
 <'> /ʔ/

*Hausa k with hook (U+0199) is often used by native speakers.

¹ Though it is beyond the scope of this paper, the issue of tone in Bura is a complicated one. Tones reported here are those heard by the transcriber; where tones are not reported, the transcriber either failed to identify them or did not feel comfortable ascribing a specific tonal measure. Sounds marked like *á* have a high tone, while *à* indicates a low tone.

Introduction

Bura-Pabir (bwr) is a Chadic language spoken by the Bura-Pabir people in regions of northeastern Nigeria^{2,3}. With 551,000 speakers as of 2023 (Eberhard et al., 2025), Bura-Pabir is a threatened language that has also gone largely under-documented and understudied. Moreover, what research is publicly available presents a disorganized picture of Bura-Pabir's (henceforth, Bura) tense, aspect, and mood (TAM) system. The most thorough study on Bura's TAM intricacies by Blench (2012) was based largely on data collected via telephone conversations with local language consultants and is highly conflictual with more current work by Mshelbwala (2022) and earlier work by Davies (1954). Thus, the documented grammar of Bura is in need of refinement and clarification. To flesh out how tense, aspect, mood, and, to a lesser extent, modality, are marked in Bura, I conducted 13 half-hour in-person interviews with Yakubu, a native speaker of the Hyil Hawul dialect of Bura. The present document acts as a record of what these sessions revealed and does not seek to advance a narrow argument about any one aspect of Bura grammar. I begin with a brief clarification of the pronominal system in Bura, followed by overviews of tense, aspect, mood, and modality marking. Due to the inherent temporal limitations of the elicitations, work on Bura is far from over; I conclude by identifying areas for future investigation in Bura.

² The author would like to thank Yakubu Bitrus for offering up his language for study, as well as Sergio Salazar Rodo for his assistance with collecting data during elicitation sessions.

³ The following abbreviations will be used throughout: ACC: Accusative; adp: Adposition; adv: Adverb; COMP: Complementizer; COMPL: Completive; COMPLT: Completionist; coordconn: Coordinator; DAT: Dative; det: Determiner; EMPH: Emphatic; EXCL: Exclusive (of the addressee); FUT: Future; HAB: Habitual; INCL: Inclusive (of the addressee); n: Noun; NOM: Nominative; PL: Plural; POSS: Possessive; pro: Pronoun; PROG: Progressive; prt: Particle; PST: Past; REFL: Reflexive; SG: Singular; Trans: Transitive; v: Verb

The Pronominal System of Bura

The following table depicts the pronouns of Bura. Bura inflects pronouns for both morphological Case and, in the case of the 1SG and 1PL.EXCL pronouns, for Tense. Squiggle lines indicate a tentative diagnosis of allomorphy, though this will be discussed in greater detail in the **Conclusion**. Bura also has a pronoun marking a dual referent (‘the two of us’) and additionally makes a distinction between addressee-inclusive and -exclusive in the 1PL. Bura pronouns are not morphologically marked for semantic gender. As a final clarification, dative constructions must be expressed periphrastically and on the pronoun: the Dative particle *là* is used with an optional preceding *a* to refer to a pronoun marked for Dative case.

	Singular			Plural				Dual
	1	2	3	1.INCL	1.EXCL	2	3	1
NOM	í	gá ~ gè	tà ~ tèt ~ ⁴ tsà	mbúrù	yèrú	gìrà	dá	mwá
NOM (FUT/PROG)	⁵ yà	gáá	tàà	mbúr ~ mbúrà	yàà/ ⁶ yèr	gìr	dáá	-
ACC	rá	ngà	dá	yèrú	gìrí	gìrí	yèrú	yèrú
DAT ((a) là +)	⁷ lí	gà	rí ~ ⁸ ní	yèrú	gìrí	gìrí	dá ~ ⁸ dá	yèrú
REFL	krí	kèrngà	kràrí ~ kèrní	kèrmbúrù ~ kràmbúrù	kèrgìrí ~ krágìrí	kèrgìrí ~ krágìrí	kèrdá	krámwá

⁴ *Tsà* is only attested in cases where it is necessary to distinguish *tà* from an isomorphic segment, such as the comparative particle *ta*. As with *tà*, Bura does not make a gender distinction in the 3SG pronoun with *tsà*.

⁵ *Yà* is also the 1SG.NOM subject pronoun when it precedes the negation particle *adĩ*, regardless of the construction’s overall tense. This is the result of hiatus resolution via glide transformation: the 1SG pronoun ‘í’ becomes *yà* when it precedes a vowel as in *adĩ*. This same pattern is observed in the case of the 1SG.DAT *lí* and constructions including the complementizer *ka* followed by *í*.

⁶ *yèr* is present only in progressive contexts preceding the particle *akwa*.

⁷ Owing to a phonological operation resolving hiatus, the 1SG.Dative pronoun is actually *í*. However, when this follows the Dative particle *là*, the first vowel drops and the forms combine to form *lí*. Yakubu indicated that the alternative, *là í*, is ungrammatical.

⁸ Both of these forms occur when the Dative particle is omitted and are not possible when it is present.

An extended discussion of the Bura pronominal system is beyond the scope of this investigation. However, a possible re-analysis of these forms could divide them into a Main Set and an ‘A-set.’ Pronouns in the ‘A-set’ would be those found preceding vowel-initial (specifically *a*) pre-verbal particles, such as *akwa* or *ata*. Broadwell (p.c.) suggests that this partition could have arisen from a phonological alternation in early Bura that has been grammaticalized as a set of specialized pronouns. Future work on Bura should aim to clarify whether this dichotomy is supported by more varied speaker data.

Tense Marking in Bura

Tense in Bura is unmarked in past and present contexts, but it is obligatorily marked with a preverbal particle *ata* when expressing the future. Present and past tensed constructions are indistinguishable save for when there is a temporal adverb that clarifies the event temporality, such as the adverb *náhà*, meaning ‘yesterday,’ in **Example 2**.

1. i kwás shìngkáfá
 i kwás shìngkáfá
 i kwás shìngkáfá
 I eat rice
 pro v n
 I eat/ate rice.
2. i kwás shìngkáfá náhà
 i kwás shìngkáfá náhà
 i kwás shìngkáfá náhà
 I eat rice yesterday
 pro v n adv
 I ate rice yesterday.

The past tense can also be marked verbally with the completive suffix *-mta* (**Example 3**) or its allomorph *-ta*, which appears when a verb has a final nasal consonant (**Example 4**).

3. í kwásmta dǽvá náhà
 í kwás -mta dǽvá náhà
 ì+SP. VAR. OF kwás -mta₂ dǽvá náhà
 1SG.nom eat COMPL food yesterday
 pro v v:Any n adv
 I had eaten/ate food yesterday.
4. í hyəngta là ga
 í hyəng -ta là ga
 ì+SP. VAR. OF hyəng -mta₂ la₂ gà
 1SG.nom to send COMPL DAT 2SG.DAT
 pro v v:Any prt pro
 I sent it to you.

However, Yakubu also indicated that the completive suffix is not limited to past tense readings (as in **Examples 3 & 4**) and can also be used to indicate that an event will be completed in the future. This finding diverges from Mshelbwala's hypothesis that verbs marked with *-mta* can only be interpreted as past completed actions. If this were the case, we would not expect **Example 5** to be grammatical. However, the inclusion of the temporal adverbial *dǽpá* ('tomorrow') establishes that an event will occur tomorrow, and *kwásmta*, 'complete eating,' is acceptable.

5. Yà kwásmta dǽvá dǽpá
 yà kwás -mta dǽvá dǽpá
 yà kwás -mta₂ dǽvá dǽpá
 1SG.NOM eat COMPL food tomorrow
 pro v v:Any n adv
 I will have eaten food tomorrow.

An interesting datum for which I was unable to identify a solution was found when trying to indicate that a third person singular or plural subject had completed an action in the past. These subjects are obligatorily marked with the suffix *-k* whenever a verb is marked with *-mta* and has already occurred, such as in **Examples 6** and **7**; curiously, Yakubu also indicated that this *-k* can also appear when the verb is not marked with the completive morpheme, but these examples appear to be relatively uncommon and always refer to a past completed action (see **Example 8**). Moreover, Yakubu stated that this suffix cannot attach to any other pronoun and is limited to the third person pronoun marked with nominative case.

6. Tàk rùbùtúm̐ta náhà
 tà -k rùbùtú -mta náhà
 tà -k rùbùtú -mta₂ náhà
 3SG.NOM PST? write COMPL yesterday
 pro pro:3 v v:Any adv

S/he had written it yesterday.

7. Dàk rùbùtúm̐ta náhà
 dà -k rùbùtú -mta náhà
 dà -k rùbùtú -mta₂ náhà
 3PL.NOM PST? write COMPL yesterday
 pro pro:3 v v:Any adv

They had written it yesterday.

8. Tàk rùbùta náhà
 tà -k rùbùta náhà
 tà -k rùbùtú náhà
 3SG.NOM PST? write yesterday
 pro pro:3 v adv

S/he wrote yesterday

Verbs are marked for the future tense via a pre-verbal particle represented underlyingly as *ata*. Bura allows for multiple pathways for future-marking: the most common of these is an assimilation of the *a* to the preceding subject when that subject is a pronoun (**Example 9**). This gives rise to the aforementioned ‘A-set’ pronominals. When a subject is a proper name, however, this *a* no longer assimilates to the subject and can instead be expressed as a free morpheme preceding the verb (**Example 10**).

9. Mbúra		dók	ngá
mbúr	-a	dók	ngá
mbúrù ₁ +UNSPEC. VAR. OF	-a ₂	dók	ngá
1PL.INCL.NOM	FUT	punch	2SG.ACC
pro	pro:Any	v	pro

We all will punch you

10. Jude	a	kwás	shìngkáfání	
	a	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní
	a	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní ₁
	FUT	eat	rice	definite
	prt	v	n	n:Any

Jude will eat the rice.

A less common means of expressing the future is by assimilating *a* to the subject and also incorporating a pre-verbal particle *ta* (**Example 11**). This is also found in sentences with proper names, albeit without vowel assimilation (**Example 12**). *Ta* can also occasionally appear alone as a pre-verbal particle, but these examples were judged by Yakubu as far less common than the previously mentioned pathways (**Example 13**). One environment where *ta* is required are subject-focus constructions where the subject is focused by an immediately post-subject *àn* (**Examples 14 & 15**). If a subject is under focus, it cannot experience vowel assimilation,

suggesting that subjects and the focus particle form a constituent. This is most clearly illustrated by **15**, where the 1SG pronoun does not undergo hiatus resolution and remains *í*.

11. Mbura		ta	dók	ngá
mbur	-a	ta	dók	ngá
mbúrù ₁	-a ₂	ta ₆	dók	ngá
1PL.INCL.NOM	FUT	FUT	punch	2SG.ACC
pro	pro:Any	preverb	v	pro

We all will punch you

12. Jude	a	ta	kwás	shìngkáfá	ní
	a	ta	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní
	a	ta ₄	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní ₁
	FUT	FUT	eat	rice	definite
	prt	preverb	v	n	n:Any

Jude will eat the rice.

13. gá		ta	kwás	shìngkáfá	ní
	gá	ta	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní
	gá	ta ₄	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní ₁
	2SG.NOM	FUT	eat	rice	definite
	pro	preverb	v	n	n:Any

You will eat the rice.

14. Kucheli	àn	ta	màs	kíí	ní
kucheli	àn	ta	màs	kíí	ní
kúchèlí	àn	ta ₄	màs	kíí	ní ₃
personal name	focus	FUT	buy	house	"the"
n	prt	preverb	v	n	det

It is Kucheli who will buy the house.

15. í	àn	ta	kwás	shìngkàfání	
í	àn	ta	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní
í	àn	ta ₄	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní ₁
1SG.NOM	focus	FUT	eat	rice	definite
pro	prt	preverb	v	n	n:Any
It is I who will eat the rice					

The least common means of expressing the future was via a surface realization of the underlying *ata*. This seemed to be possible only for proper names and was impermissible when the subject was a pronoun (**Examples 16 & 17**). One potential explanation is that Bura disprefers vowel clusters extending over a word boundary and so aims to reduce hiatus whenever possible. This would also explain why *a ta* is less frequently attested.

16. Jude	ata	kwás	shìngkàfání	
	ata	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní
	a	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní ₁
	FUT	eat	rice	definite
	prt	v	n	n:Any

Jude will eat the rice.

17. *	Mburu	ata	dók	ngá
	mburu	ata	dók	ngá
	mbúru ₂	a	dók	ngá
	1PL.INCL.NOM	FUT	punch	2SG.ACC
	pro	prt	v	pro

Attempted: We all will punch you

Perhaps the future particle is not underlying *ata*. This is, however, somewhat unlikely. Without *ata*, there is no solid explanation for why we observe such pronominal diversity in future (and progressive) contexts save for one which appeals to phonology. Additionally, how

would one explain the form of the 1SG pronoun in the future, *yà* (e.g., **Example 5**)? In the present, this pronoun is *í* before verbs which begin with a vowel such as *anfani* (‘use’) and before vowel-initial focus markers (**Example 15**), suggesting that the introduction of the glide is not a context-less phonological alternation. The explanation for why *í* only becomes *yà* in the future (and progressive) must then lie with some quality of the future particle, which transparently enough contains *ta*. Thus, *ata* represents the best possible proposal for the underlying form of the future particle; this conclusion is also corroborated by similar glosses from Davies (1954), Hartmann et al. (2008), and Zimmerman (2007). A similar line of reasoning applies to representing the progressive aspectual marker as *akwa* rather than *kwá* (cf. Zimmerman (2007)) For the duration of this work, I assume these two underlying forms.⁹

As a final note, it does not appear to be possible in Bura to express a progressive action in the future. Attempts to use the progressive marker *kwá* in sentences with the future particle were ungrammatical (**Example 18**). Rather than assuming that tense and aspect share the same node in the syntax of Bura, I assume that Bura does not express future events as ongoing. The alternative assumption would be moreover fairly atypical: we would not generally expect aspect and tense to be expressed in the same position in syntax.

18. *	Kucheli	àn	ta	kwá	kwás	shìngkàfání	
	kucheli	àn	ta	kwá	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní
	kúchəĺí	àn	ta ₄	kwá ₂	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní ₁
	personal name	focus	FUT	PROG	eat	rice	definite
	n	p _{rt}	preverb	preverb	v	n	n:Any

Attempted: It is Kucheli who will be eating the rice.

⁹ It is also worth noting that Yakubu uses *akwa* and *kwá* interchangeably, and he was generally not opposed to representing *ata* as *a ta* and vice versa (barring previously discussed preferences for subject type. That Yakubu is comfortable doing so suggests minimally that these forms are one and the same.

In summary, Bura verbs can be marked for three different tenses (the present, past, and future), with the former two being indistinguishable without a disambiguating temporal adverbial and the latter being expressed by the pre-verbal particle *ata*. I transition now to a discussion of Bura aspectual marking.

Aspectual Marking in Bura

Bura relies primarily on pre-verbal particles to mark verb aspect and in some limited cases marks aspect as a verbal suffix. The following verbal aspects are marked in Bura: the progressive, the negative progressive, the habitual and iterative, the inceptive and terminative, ‘thoroughness,’ and Completion from both the subject and object’s perspective. I will present data for each of these aspects in the order presented.

The Progressive and Negative Progressive Aspect

Verbs are marked for progressive aspect with the preverbal particle *kwá* (**Example 19**) or *akwa* (**Example 20**). Importantly, this particle triggers the vowel hiatus resolution observed in future-tense contexts, so pronouns such as *í* are obligatorily *yà*, indicating that *kwá* is indeed underlying *akwa*.

19. *yà kwá kwás shìngkáfá*
 yà kwá kwás shìngkáfá
 yà kwá₂ kwás shìngkáfá
 1SG.NOM PROG eat rice
 pro preverb v n

I am eating rice.

20. Jude *akwa ngùr Sergio*
 akwa ngùr
 akwa ngùr
 PROG drive
 preverb v

Jude is driving Sergio.

Bura also appears to have a specialized progressive marker *tá* for constructions including the negation particle *dĩ* (**Example 21 & 22**) This particle is homophonous to the future tense particle *ta*, but it does not exclusively carry a future meaning, since it appears in constructions referring to actions taking place in the current moment and to future ongoing actions (**Example 23**) Moreover, we do not observe the use of a pronoun from the ‘A-set’ in these constructions; *tá* in **Example 22** is not lengthened, so this *tá* cannot be underlyingly *ata*.

21. yà	dĩ	tá	nàm	kííní		wa
yà	dĩ	tá	nàm	kíí	-ní	wà
yà	dĩ	tá	nàm ₂	kíí	-ní ₁	wà
1SG.NOM	not	NEG.PROG	make, cause	house		definite
pro	adv	preverb	v	n	n:Any	prt

I am not cleaning the house (at the present moment)

22. tá	dĩ	tá	nàm	kííní		wa
tá	dĩ	tá	nàm	kíí	-ní	wà
tá	dĩ	tá	nàm ₂	kíí	-ní ₁	wà
3SG.NOM	not	NEG.PROG	make, cause	house		definite
pro	adv	preverb	v	n	n:Any	prt

S/he is not cleaning the house (at the present moment)

23. yà	dĩ	tá	nam	kííní		wa
yà	dĩ	tá	nam	kíí	-ní	wà
yà	adĩ	tá	nàm ₂	kíí	-ní ₁	wà
1SG.?	not	NEG.PROG	make, cause	house		definite
pro	adv	preverb	v	n	n:Any	prt

It is not I that will be cleaning the house.

However, this *tá* is grammatically and semantically interchangeable with the progressive marker *kwá*, though they cannot occur together, indicating that these two markers likely index the same grammatical meaning (compare **Example 24** with **Example 24B** and **24B** with **21**). Minimally, however, *tá* as a (tentatively proposed) negative progressive marker is only licit when there is a negation particle in the clause.

24. *	yà	dí	tá	kwá	nam	kíní		wa
	yà	dí	tá	kwá	nam	kíí	-ní	wà
	yà	adí	tá	kwá ₂	nàm ₂	kíí	-ní ₁	wà
	1SG.?	not	NEG.PROG	PROG	make, cause	house		definite
	pro	adv	preverb	preverb	v	n	n:Any	prt

Attempted: It is not I that is cleaning (at the present moment)

24B.	yà	dí	kwá	nàm	kíní		wá
	yà	dí	kwá	nàm	kíí	-ní	wá
	yà	adí	kwá ₂	nàm ₁	kíí	-ní ₁	wá ₁
	1SG.NOM	not	PROG	patch	house	definite	NEG
	pro	adv	preverb	v	n	n:Any	prt

I am not cleaning the house at the present moment.

Yakubu also indicated that the use of *tá* signals something analogous to the future progressive: sentences with *tá* can refer to an event ongoing in the present or one which will happen in the future (compare **21** with **23**). At the moment, I do not have a clear analysis beyond that it appears to be a specialized version of the progressive marker for negation sentences which is in free variation with the progressive marker. Perhaps this particle is a holdover from an older generation of Bura; there may also be a pragmatic difference between sentences with *kwá* and *tá*. I did not collect this data, however, so this is purely speculative.

The Habitual and Iterative

These two verbal aspects can both be expressed using the pre-verbal particle *ná*, which has been glossed as HAB for brevity's sake. Yakubu indicated that constructions including *ná* can be interpreted as referring to an event which is regular (i.e, habitual) (**Example 25**) or repeated (i.e., iterative) (**Example 26**), These interpretations are shown in examples below.

25. yà ná màs suger
 yà ná màs suger
 yà ná màs suger
 1SG.NOM HAB buy sugar
 pro preverb v n
 I buy sugar regularly
26. Gá ná kwás shìngkáfá
 gá ná kwás shìngkáfá
 gá ná kwás shìngkáfá
 2SG.NOM HAB eat rice
 pro preverb v n

You habitually eat rice OR you repeatedly eat rice.

Bura also allows partial (**Example 27**) or full reduplication (**Example 28**) of the verb to indicate that an action is iterative. When verbs are partially reduplicated, it appears to be of the first full syllable. Yakubu did not indicate there to be a semantic or grammatical difference between partial and full reduplication. Regardless of the extent of reduplication, they are exclusively interpreted as iterative.

27. dīhīdīhī

dīhī-dīhī

dīhī-dīhī

swim-swim

v

swim repeatedly

28. dīdīhī

dī-dīhī

dī-dīhī

CV-swim

v

swim repeatedly

The Inceptive and Terminative

As in English, Bura indicates that an event has begun or ended through the use of pre-verbal particles which also function as stand-alone verbs. In this case, *bítù* ('begin') marks inceptive aspect (**Example 29**), while *kúrí* ('finish, end') marks terminative aspect (**Example 30**).

29. í	bítù	nduɓu	lèptúní	
í	bítù	nduɓu	lèptú	-ní
í	bítù	nduɓu	lèpthù	-ní ₁
1SG.NOM	begin	sew	shirt	definite
pro	v	v	n	n:Any
I began/begin to sew the shirt				

30. í	kúri	rùbùtú
í	kúri	rùbùtú
í	kúri	rùbùtú
1SG.NOM	finish	write
pro	v	v
I finished writing		

‘Thoroughness’

Verbs marked with the suffix *-bəla* are interpreted as having been performed thoroughly. For instance, in **Example 31**, the speaker or subject has thoroughly packed some objects. This morpheme is attested in all available literature on Bura verbal extensions as meaning approximately the same thing, though Mshelbwala (2022) notes that this thoroughness is from “from the point of the actor [sic]” (p. 127). Though Mshelbwala does not dedicate prolonged discussion to this nuance, the likely interpretation is that *-bəla* encodes the doer’s assessment of the extent of the action, rather than describing an objective state of affairs. However, Yakubu did not appear to make this distinction.

31. í	fa	bəla
í	fá	-bəla
í	fá ₂	-bəla
1SG.NOM	remove	thoroughly
pro	v	v:Any
I packed (it) thoroughly		

Completive and Completionist

Bura makes a distinction between completion of an action on an object (the Completive aspect)) and actions performed on a complete set of objects (the Completionist aspect). The former is marked with the verbal suffix *-mta* or its allomorph *-ta*, while the latter is marked with

the verbal suffix *-mya* (for the sake of brevity, this is a tentative gloss; examples with *-mya* showcase several allomorphs subsumed under *-mya*). Verbs marked with *-mta* have been completed or will have been completed and are thus incompatible with progressive contexts which would imply an action or event is still ongoing (**Examples 32 & 33**). *-mya*, by contrast, indicates that a complete set (i.e., all of X, where X is an object) of objects has been impacted by a verb, which need not necessarily have been completed (**Example 34**).

32. Ya kwásmta dǽvá dǽpá
 ya kwás -mta dǽvá dǽpá
 yà kwás -mta₂ dǽvá dǽpá
 1SG.NOM eat COMPL food tomorrow
 pro v v:Any n adv

I will have eaten food tomorrow.

33. báthl - mtá
 báthl -mtá
 báthl -mta₂
 dance COMPL
 v v:Any

Completed dancing, had danced [Data from Jessica Heady, adapted by author]

34. í kwásimya dǽvá náhà
 í kwás -imya dǽvá náhà
 í kwás -mya dǽvá náhà
 1SG.NOM eat COMPLT food yesterday
 pro v v:Trans n adv

I had eaten (all of the) food yesterday

Given their phonological and semantic similarities, it may be tempting to argue that these morphemes are allomorphs of one another. However, they exhibit distinct preferences as to the verbs they attach to. *-mya* exclusively appears with transitive and labile verbs, with the latter

requiring an explicit nominal object, but *-mta* can appear on both transitive and intransitive verbs (compare **Examples 35 & 36** to **Examples 34 & 33**, respectively).

35. * í kwás - imnya
 í kwás -imya
 í kwás -mya
 1SG.NOM eat COMPLT
 pro v v:Trans

Attempted: I ate (all of it). [Data from Jessica Heady, adapted by author]

36. * báthl - mnya
 báthl -mnya
 báthl -mya
 dance COMPLT
 v v:Trans

danced [Data from Jessica Heady, adapted by author]

If *-mya* was simply an allomorph of *-mta*, we would not expect it to display such a differential attachment pattern; moreover, an argument from phonology is weakened by the fact that *-mta* and *-mya* can attach to the same transitive/labile verbs. That *-mya* attaches exclusively to verbs taking objects also comports well with its analysis as a ‘total’ marker indicating an action has occurred on all of an object or objects. Conversely, all verbs can be plausibly completed regardless of their transitivity, and thus *-mta*’s distribution is intelligible only if it is interpreted as marking the completion of an event.

Yakubu, however, often gave readings for both verbal completion and completion on an object when either verbal extension was used (**Examples 37 & 38**). When I asked about this lack of distinction, Yakubu reported that this aspectual difference is a site of generational language shift. Older generations before Yakubu’s prefer to use *-mta* to mark both meanings, while younger generations including Generation Z speakers of Bura prefer to use *-mya*. Yakubu’s

generation evidently is caught between these two generational currents and so may use the forms interchangeably with one another. Future research on Bura would do good to probe speakers from different generations for their interpretations of these verbal extensions.

37. í	kwásmya		dǝvání	
í	kwás	-mya	dǝvá	-ní
í	kwás	-mya	dǝvá	-ní ₁
1SG.NOM	eat	COMPLT	food	definite
pro	v	v:Trans	n	n:Any

I have finished/completed eating the food OR I have eaten all of the food.

38. í	hyəngta		tasaní	
í	hyəng	-ta	tasa	-ní
í	hyəng	-mta ₁	tásā	-ní ₁
1SG.NOM	to send	COMPL	plate, bowl	definite
pro	v	v:Any	n	n:Any

I have finished sending the plates OR I have completely sent the plates.

Mood in Bura

Bura does not appear to mark extensively for mood, with realis moods not differing from irrealis moods in terms of their verbal extensions. For instance, constructions designed to elicit a subjunctive mood do not differ morphologically from sentences in the indicative mood

(Example 39).

39. Mì	í	ápà	gá	yà	kwás	shìngkáfání	
mì	í	ápà	gá	yà	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní
mì	í	ápà	gá	yà	kwás	shìngkáfá	-ní ₁
if	1SG.NOM	like	2SG.NOM	1SG.NOM	eat	rice	definite
prt	pro	coord	pro	pro	v	n	n:Any

If I were you, I would eat the rice.

Bura does, however, mark epistemic and deontic mood through the use of pre-verbal particles and ‘framing devices’ such as *yà kamata ka*, which precedes the main clause. Epistemic mood is marked primarily using the pre-verbal particle *tsokta*, meaning ‘could’ or ‘can.’ This same particle can also carry a weak deontic sense such that a verb is interpreted as optional or not strongly required, according to Yakubu (**Examples 40 & 41**).

40. yà	tsokta	dīhi	ákwá	zirko	d̥pá	ama	ápà	yímí	a	hàrá
yà	tsokta	dīhi	ákwá	zirko	d̥pá	ama	ápà	yímí	a	hàrá
yà	tsokta	dīhi	ákwá	zirkù	d̥pá	ama	ápà	yímí	á ₁	hàrá
1SG.NOM	could, can	swim	in	river	tomorrow	but	like	water	to	do
pro	modal	v	adp	n	adv	coordconn	coord	n	prt	v

I could swim in the river tomorrow, but it will rain.

41. Kucheli	àn	ta	tsokta	kwás	shìngkàfání	
kucheli	àn	ta	tsokta	kwás	shìngkàfà	-ní
kúchèlí	àn	ta ₄	tsokta	kwás	shìngkáfà	-ní ₁
personal name	focus	FUT	could, can	eat	rice	definite
n	prt	preverb	modal	v	n	n:Any

It is Kucheli who could eat the rice.

Yà kamata ka is a deontic marker used to indicate that an action should or ought to take place. Importantly, this deontic marker acts as a framing device preceding the main clause, as evidenced by its position in sentences and the presence of the COMPLEMENTIZER *ka*. Yakubu stated that *yà* in *yà kamata ka* is the 1SG pronoun, but this frame can appear in any subject-person context (**Example 42**).

42. yà	kamata	ká	Sergio	butla
yà	kamata	ká		butla
yà	kamata ₂	ká ₁		butla
1SG.NOM	should	complementizer		to cough
pro	modal	COMP		v

Sergio needs to cough OR Sergio should cough.

There does not appear to be any literal meaning of *kamata*, and it is not present as a verb or otherwise in any constructions by itself. We can also observe another instance of Bura's preference for hiatus resolution: when *yà kamata ka* precedes the 1SG pronoun, *ka* becomes *ki* (**Example 43**).

43. yà	kamata	ki		kwás	shìngkáfá
yà	kamata	k	-i	kwás	shìngkáfá
yà	kamata ₂	ká ₁	í	kwás	shìngkáfá
1SG.NOM	should	complementizer	1SG.NOM	eat	rice
pro	modal	COMP	pro	v	n
I should eat rice					

Doli ka, 'must,' is also used as a framing device indicating that an action is of extreme necessity and that a speaker is highly obligated to perform the verb (**Example 44**). *Doli* is an Arabic borrowing, while *ka* is the complementizer 'that.'

44. doli	ká	Jude	mandába	la	Sergio
doli	ká		mandába	la	
doli	ká ₁		mandába	la ₂	
must	complementizer	hit		DATIVE	
modal	COMP	v		prt	

Jude (absolutely) needs to punch Sergio.

47. yà bára lúkwà kuta kíír nga
 yà bára lúkwà kuta kíí -r nga
 yà bára lúkwà₂ kuta kíí -r nga
 1SG.NOM want to enter in inside house genitive you/your
 pro v v adp n n:Any pro

I want to enter your house

48. A: Náha Pindár sá mbal.
 yesterday P. drink beer
 ‘Yesterday Pindar drank beer.’

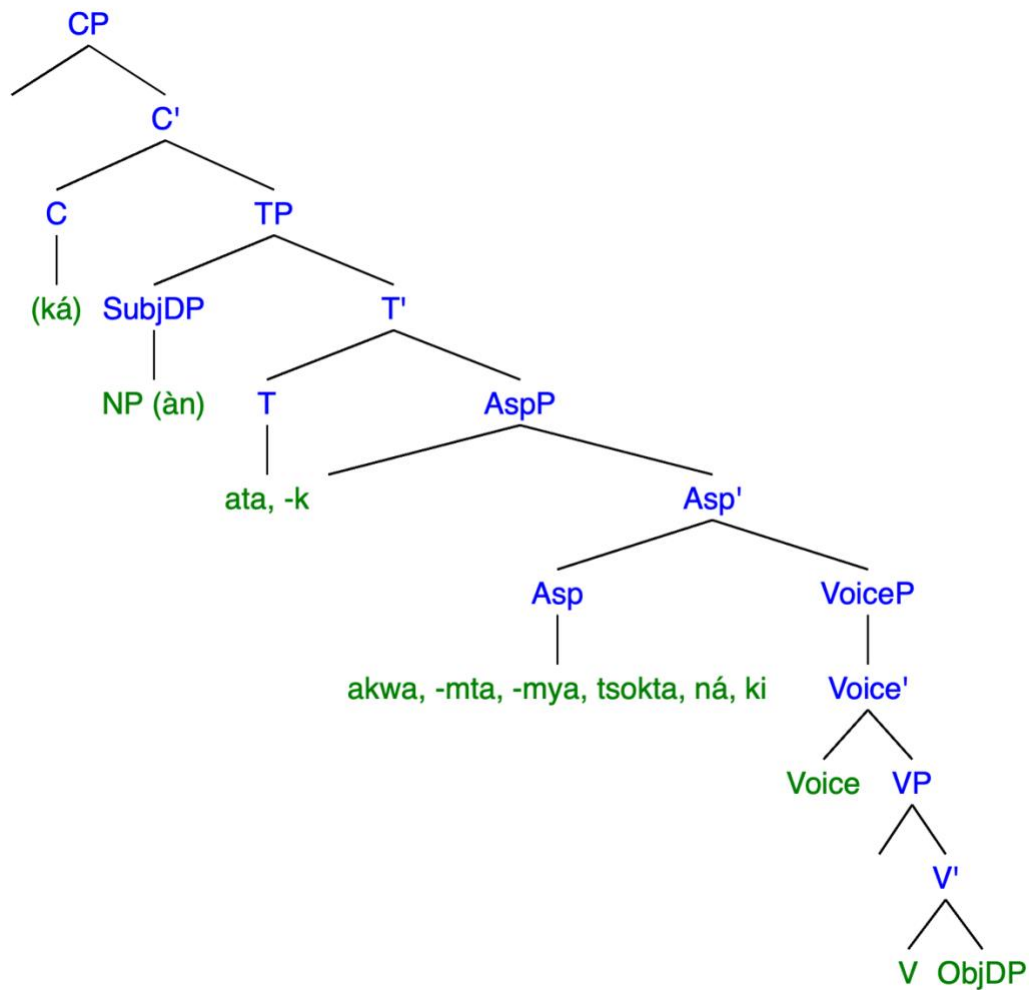
 B: A’á, Pindár (**ku**) sá mbal náha.
 yes P. POL drink beer yesterday
 ‘Yes, Pindar **did** drink beer yesterday.’

[Example #45 in Hartmann et al. (2008)]

The Syntax of Bura

Taking these morphological facts into account, I will propose a minimal syntactic structure for Bura. Given the spatial limitations of this text, I will not dedicate an extensive discussion of each component in this structure, nor should it be assumed that this is the entire picture of Bura syntax. Future work will be required to stress-test these findings. Given the linear order of the earlier examples, and given certain unacceptable structures attested here, I propose the following structure:

Image 1: Proposed Minimal Syntax for Bura



I propose that Bura as an Aspect projection in which aspectual and mood morphology is marked. There does not appear to be multiple Aspect projections, nor is there likely to be a separate, Mood projection. This is evidenced by the fact that it is always ungrammatical to have both an aspect and a mood marker preverbally; acceptable constructions may only have one or the other. For instance, attempts to express a habitual action emphatically using, respectively, *ná* and *ki*, were unsuccessful (Example 49).

49. *	Mbur	ná	ki	dfihì	kulum vir
	mbur	ná	ki	dfihì	kulum vir
	mbúrù ₁	ná	ki ₁	dfihi	kulum vir
	1PL.INCL.NOM	HAB	EMPH	swim	every day
	pro	preverb	preverb	v	adv

Attempted: We all DO regularly swim

Per Yakubu, one could use the habitual marker with a post-verbal temporal adverb *kulum vir* ('every day'), or one could simply use the emphatic marker without the habitual to obtain this interpretation (**Example 50**). Thus, since Bura prohibits multiple aspect and mood markers, it is reasonable to assume that these markers (both the particles and the verbal suffixes) are represented in the same projection in structure.

50.	Mbur	na	dfihì	kulum vir
	mbur	na	dfihì	kulum vir
	mbúrù ₁	na ₁	dfihi	kulum vir
	1PL.INCL.NOM	HAB	swim	every day
	pro	preverb	v	adv

We all swim every day habitually

Future tense and possibly the nebulous *-k* morpheme are marked in the Tense phrase, with the subject raising from the specifier of VoiceP to optionally assimilate with the vowel in *ata*. This is strongly evidenced by constructions where both verbal extensions are present alongside aspectual morphology on the verb (**Examples 5, 6, & 7**). In subject-focus constructions, we find that subjects marked for the future tense (or, additionally, with *-k*) cannot be focused. In order for a subject-focus construction to be expressed in the future tense, subject pronouns cannot assimilate with the initial vowel of *ata* (**Example 51**).

51. * Mbura		àn	kwás	shìngkàfání	
mbur	-a	àn	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní
mbùrù ₁	-a ₂	àn	kwás	shìngkàfá	-ní ₁
1PL.INCL.NOM	FUT	focus	eat	rice	definite
pro	v:Any	prt	v	n	n:Any

Attempted: It is us who will eat the rice

As a result, the 1SG pronoun is expressed as *í*, rather than *yà* (**Example 15**). This suggests that the subject contains the focus marker within its DP and thus the vowel assimilation cannot occur exclusively onto the subject pronoun. A similar logic holds for sentences using *-k*, where *tàk* cannot be focused by *àn* (**Example 52**).

52. * Tàk		àn	rùbùtú	náhà	
tà	-k	àn	rùbùtú	náhà	
tà	-k	àn	rùbùtú	náhà	
3SG.NOM	PST?	focus	write	yesterday	
pro	v:Any	prt	v	adv	

Attempted: It is s/he who wrote yesterday.

In short, Bura subjects raise into the specifier of TP to satisfy the Extended Projection Principle, with an optional focus marker in the DP. Meanwhile, the verb raises from the head of the VP into Asp, where either takes a verbal suffix or a pre-verbal particle; presumably, when the tense head is empty, as it is in non-future contexts, it also raises into T by the Minimal Link Condition. However, when this head is occupied by *ata* and possibly by *-k*, the verb remains low. This is a barebones analysis of Bura syntax, but it is also closely corroborated by contemporary work (see. Hartmann et al. (2008) for a similar proposed structure).

Conclusions

I have presented, on the basis of data collected through a semester's worth of elicitation sessions with a native speaker, a general overview of the tense, aspect, and mood marking systems in Bura, along with a basic sketch of its syntactic structure. Bura tends to mark TAM preverbally as particles, although it also marks certain aspectual information on the verb. Bura thus tends to be largely analytic in its morphological patterns, with some synthetic inclinations. Several important questions, however, remain. Firstly, this research failed to identify morphemes previously documented by other work in Bura, including but not limited to the causative *-nta*, the collective marker *-ha*, the inceptive *-(r)ar*, and a marker signaling that an action has only been partially completed. I document the major differences in findings in **Appendix A**: work from Davies (1954), Blench (2012), and Mshelbwala (2022) is reported, since these are the most comprehensive works on Bura grammar which are available. It is of course worth noting that an absence in my data is not evidence that the marker does not exist or that Bura speakers lack this category of verbal extension. Necessarily, my data is limited in that it is produced by a single speaker in half-hour increments over the course of 13 weeks. This said, I did attempt to explicitly elicit these forms from Yakubu, who either did not recognize these verbal extensions or stated that they were unfaithful to actual Bura.

Of these scholars, Blench's data appears to be the most problematic in this respect: Yakubu reported that Blench collected the vast majority of his data via telephone to Yakubu's community, which raises immediate concerns about the acoustic quality of Blench's data. Moreover, it is possible Blench (as well as Davies and Mshelbwala) surveyed an older speaker whose intuitions and grammatical knowledge may diverge from Yakubu's. Thus, there is a two-fold adjustment required of future Bura work: data collection would ideally be in-field and/or in

more controlled phonological environments to guarantee both a naturalistic speech environment and an acoustically felicitous analysis; and, data should be collected for different generations of Bura speakers to identify whether some of the omissions in **Appendix A** are in fact the product of shifting linguistic behavior. There are also specific areas of interest future research should investigate, such as a thorough sketch of the pronominal system. I have omitted possessive pronouns from the chart displayed here, but ongoing work suggests that there is a rather intricate system marking alienable and inalienable possessives. Future research should also aim to tease apart habitual and iterative readings of verbs: this investigation reported that *ná* marked both of these aspects, but the available literature suggests a more diverse system including durative readings via reduplication. These elicitation sessions may have failed to control more effectively for one reading over another and so missed out on a verbal extension. In brief, the present paper functions not only as a basic overview of Bura TAM, but also as a springboard for future reference and research.

Appendix A

Verbal Extension Comparison Chart

	Davies	Blench	Mshelbwala	Singleton
Pluperfect	N-a(n)	?	?	?
Medio-Passive	V-dzi	V-dzi	?	V-dzi
Compleitive	V _{intrans} -ta V _{trans} -mta	V _{intrans} -ta V _{trans} -mta <i>On mult. obj.:</i> V-gi-/gu-V, V-ga	V-ta <i>In PerfP:</i> V-mta	V-mta/-nta V _{FINAL NASAL} -ta
Causative	V _{trans} -nta V _{intrans} -mta	V _{trans} -nta V _{intrans} -mta	-nta	?
Partial Action	V-ata N _{some}	V-tsa <i>From sp. persp.</i>	V-r <i>On some obj.:</i> V-tsa	?
Incompleitive	V-r	V-(r)ar	V-r	?
Total Action	V-mya	V-mya <i>From sp. persp.</i>	V-mnya	V-mya
Thoroughness	V-bila	V-ḃəla	V-bila <i>From sp. persp.</i>	V-ḃəla
Iterative/Habitual	V-ata P.R.	V- nkər V-ha	?	ná + V P/F.R.
Durative	P.R.	P/F. R.	?	ná + V
Past Tense	?	?	V-ri	N-k?
Infinitive	?	?	V-lari	?
Collective (‘together’)	V-ha	V-ha	?	?

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